KMVTECH Education

Environmental & Conservation Psychology

Module 1 — Foundations · Lesson 1.1

What Is Environmental & Conservation Psychology?

Learning Objectives

- Define environmental psychology and conservation psychology
- Explain the two-way relationship between people and the environment
- Identify the five goals of environmental psychology
- Distinguish between the two fields clearly

Key Terms

• Environmental Psychology	• Conservation Psychology
• Two-way relationship	• Pro-environmental behaviour
• Biophilia	• Goals of environmental psychology

1. Defining the Two Fields

Environmental psychology studies the two-way relationship between people and the environments they live in — natural, built, and social. It asks how environments affect human thoughts, feelings, and behaviour — and how human behaviour in turn affects environments.

Conservation psychology is a sub-field with a narrower focus. It uses psychological knowledge specifically to motivate people to protect and preserve the natural world.

The core idea: the relationship goes BOTH ways.

THE ENVIRONMENT (forests, cities, wetlands, noise, green space)	→ ←	HUMAN THOUGHTS, FEELINGS & BEHAVIOUR (stress, choices, conservation, destruction)

Green arrow (→): The environment shapes how we think, feel, and behave — e.g. walking through Mabira Forest reduces stress.

Navy arrow (←): Our behaviour shapes the environment — e.g. dumping waste in wetlands destroys ecosystems.

2. How the Environment Affects Humans

Physical effects

Heat, noise, air pollution, and crowding all affect the body. A noisy road causes fatigue. Polluted air damages lungs. Extreme heat slows cognitive performance.

Psychological effects

Natural environments (parks, forests, riversides) reduce stress and restore mental focus. Crowded, dirty, or poorly maintained spaces reduce mood and increase anxiety.

Behavioural effects

The design of a space influences behaviour directly. People litter less in clean, well-maintained spaces. Bin placement affects whether waste is disposed of properly. Road design influences driving behaviour.

3. How Humans Affect the Environment

Human activities that damage the natural world include:

- Deforestation — clearing trees for charcoal, agriculture, and building
- Pollution — industrial discharge, vehicle emissions, plastic waste
- Urbanisation — converting wetlands and forests to housing and roads
- Agricultural expansion — causing soil erosion and habitat loss

Uganda Connection

In Uganda, Kampala's wetlands — once absorbing rainfall and preventing flooding — have been built over for housing. The result is worse flooding every rainy season. The two-way relationship at work: human decisions to build on wetlands changed the environment, which then created worse conditions for the very humans who built there.

4. Five Goals of Environmental Psychology

Goal	What It Means
Understand behaviour in environments	Study why people feel, think, and act differently in different places
Reduce environmental destruction	Understand why people damage environments — and design better solutions
Promote sustainable living	Understand what makes sustainable behaviour stick
Improve the design of spaces	Apply psychology to architecture, urban planning, and school design
Encourage environmental protection	Design campaigns and programs that actually change behaviour at scale

5. Environmental vs Conservation Psychology

	Environmental Psychology	Conservation Psychology
Focus	Full relationship between people and ALL environments	Specifically protecting and preserving nature
Scope	Broad — built, natural, and social environments	Narrower — conservation and environmental action
Main question	How do environments affect behaviour, and vice versa?	How do we motivate people to protect the environment?
Key founders	Roger Barker, Kaplan, Ulrich	Susan Clayton, Gene Myers

Remember

Environmental psychology is the BROADER field. Conservation psychology is an APPLIED sub-field that uses environmental psychology's theories to specifically solve the problem of environmental destruction.

✓Lesson Summary

1. Environmental psychology studies the two-way relationship between people and environments
2. Conservation psychology uses that knowledge to motivate protection of the natural world
3. The environment shapes us (physically, psychologically, behaviourally) and we shape it
4. Five goals: understand behaviour, reduce destruction, promote sustainability, improve design, encourage protection
5. The two fields complement each other — neither is sufficient alone

Quick Revision

1. Define environmental psychology in one sentence.
2. What does 'two-way relationship' mean in this context? Give one Uganda example.
3. Name three goals of environmental psychology.
4. What is the main difference between environmental psychology and conservation psychology?
5. Give one example of how the environment affects human behaviour.

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Environmental & Conservation Psychology

Module 1 — Foundations · Lesson 1.2

Historical Development & Relevance

Learning Objectives

- Trace the historical emergence of environmental psychology
- Explain Roger Barker's contribution and the concept of behaviour settings
- Explain the role of urbanisation in driving the field
- Identify the three foundational theories developed 1970s–1990s
- Explain why environmental psychology is urgently relevant today

Key Terms

• Ecological psychology	• Roger Barker
• Behaviour settings	• Urbanisation
• Attention Restoration Theory	• Stress Reduction Theory
• Place Identity Theory	• Conservation psychology

1. Early Roots — Before the 1960s

Environmental psychology did not exist as a named field before the 1960s. The relationship between people and environments was studied separately by psychology, geography, sociology, and architecture — but nobody was looking at the full picture.

The key early contribution came from Roger Barker and ecological psychology in the 1960s.

Roger Barker's Key Insight

You cannot understand human behaviour by only looking inside the person's mind. You must also look at the setting — the physical and social environment where behaviour happens. He called these behaviour settings. A person who is loud and confident at a sports field may be quiet and reserved in a library. Same person. Different setting. Different behaviour.

2. Urbanisation — The Driving Force

The other major force that made environmental psychology necessary was rapid urbanisation during industrialisation. As cities grew, new human problems emerged that existing psychology had no framework for:

- Overcrowding created stress, crime, and mental health problems
- Industrial pollution damaged physical and psychological health
- Noise from factories and traffic became a constant urban feature
- Housing shortages forced people into cramped, poorly designed spaces

Uganda Connection

> Kampala today mirrors the conditions that made environmental psychology necessary in the West 60 years ago. Overcrowding in informal settlements, traffic noise, inadequate housing, and shrinking green space are all producing the same psychological questions — how is this urban environment affecting the health and behaviour of the people living in it?

3. Formal Emergence — 1960s and 1970s

Environmental psychology emerged as a recognised academic field in the late 1960s–70s. Key research themes included:

- Personal space — how much physical distance people need from others
- The effects of noise on concentration, mood, and performance
- How urban design affects crime and mental health
- The relationship between building design and human behaviour

4. Growth of Theories — 1970s to 1990s

Three theories from this period became foundational in the field:

Theory	Author(s)	Core Idea
Attention Restoration Theory	Kaplan & Kaplan (1989)	Natural environments restore depleted mental focus through soft fascination
Stress Reduction Theory	Ulrich (1984)	Nature exposure triggers physiological stress recovery — lower heart rate, blood pressure, cortisol
Place Identity Theory	Proshansky (1978)	The places we live in become part of our personal identity

5. The Rise of Conservation Psychology — 2000s

By the late 1990s, a growing group of researchers felt environmental psychology was too focused on describing problems rather than solving them. Conservation psychology emerged — driven by researchers like Susan Clayton and Gene Myers — focused specifically on using psychology to protect the natural world.

Environmental Psychology (1960s–1970s) Studies the human–environment relationship

▼

Growth of Theories (1970s–1990s) ART · SRT · Place Identity

▼

Conservation Psychology (2000s onwards) Applied focus: how do we motivate people to protect nature?

6. Why Environmental Psychology Is Urgently Relevant Today

- Urban problems: overcrowding, noise, and the disappearance of green space affect millions in Kampala
- Environmental protection: understanding why people damage environments helps design better interventions
- Mental health and nature: access to natural environments improves wellbeing — relevant to urban planning
- Environmental policy: policymakers who understand behaviour design better environmental policies

- Global challenges: climate change and biodiversity loss require changes in human behaviour at scale

✓Lesson Summary

1. Roger Barker introduced ecological psychology and the concept of behaviour settings in the 1960s
2. Rapid urbanisation created the human problems that made environmental psychology necessary
3. The field formally emerged in the 1960s–70s, focused on crowding, noise, and urban stress
4. Three foundational theories emerged 1970s–90s: ART, SRT, and Place Identity Theory
5. Conservation psychology emerged in the 2000s as an applied sub-field focused on protecting nature
6. The field is directly relevant to Uganda's urban growth, environmental degradation, and climate challenges

Quick Revision

1. What was Roger Barker's key contribution to environmental psychology?
2. Why did urbanisation make environmental psychology necessary?
3. When did environmental psychology formally emerge as an academic field?
4. Name the three foundational theories developed between the 1970s and 1990s.
5. How does conservation psychology differ from environmental psychology historically?

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Environmental & Conservation Psychology

Module 1 — Foundations · Lesson 1.3

Theoretical Foundations — The 7 Theories

▯ Learning Objectives

- Explain all seven foundational theories in environmental psychology
- Apply each theory to a real-world environmental example
- Compare the theories and explain how they connect
- Use the formula B = f(P, E) and explain what it means

▯ Key Terms

• Attention Restoration Theory	• Directed attention
• Involuntary attention	• Soft fascination
• Stress Reduction Theory	• Biophilia
• Theory of Planned Behaviour	• Subjective norms
• Perceived behavioural control	• Norm Activation Model
• Ascription of responsibility	• Value-Belief-Norm Theory
• New Ecological Paradigm	• Place Identity
• Solastalgia	• Lewin's Field Theory

Overview

This lesson covers 7 theories. The first two explain what environments DO to us (cognitive theories). The next three explain what drives us to act (behavioural theories). The last two explain the role of identity and context.

Theory 1: Attention Restoration Theory (ART)

Authors: Rachel & Stephen Kaplan · Year: 1989

The human brain has two types of attention:

Directed Attention	Involuntary Attention (Fascination)
Effortful, deliberate, exhausting	Effortless, gentle, automatic
Required for work, study, driving	Triggered by nature — water, trees, birds
Gets depleted over time → mental fatigue	Gives directed attention time to recover

Natural environments restore directed attention through soft fascination. For an environment to be restorative it needs four properties:

BEING AWAY	FASCINATION	EXTENT

• Sense of escape from routine demands	• Elements hold attention effortlessly	• Rich enough to occupy the mind

- Fourth property: COMPATIBILITY — the environment matches what you need in that moment

🇺🇬 Uganda Connection
A walk through Mabira Forest or along Lake Victoria restores a student's mental focus after hours of studying — because it engages involuntary attention and lets directed attention recover. ART justifies keeping green spaces in Kampala's urban planning.

Theory 2: Stress Reduction Theory (SRT)

Author: Robert Ulrich · Year: 1984

Ulrich studied hospital patients recovering from surgery. Patients with TREE VIEWS vs BRICK WALL VIEWS showed:

- Faster recovery and shorter hospital stays
- Less pain medication required
- Fewer negative nursing notes

His theory: exposure to nature — even passively through a window — triggers a stress recovery response:

Nature → ↓ Blood pressure · ↓ Heart rate · ↓ Cortisol · ↓ Muscle tension

This happens within minutes of natural exposure — even looking at a photograph of nature can help

The underlying idea is biophilia — humans evolved in natural settings, so our bodies are wired to feel safe and calm in nature.

	ART	SRT
Focuses on	Cognitive restoration (mental fatigue)	Stress reduction (physiological)
Mechanism	Involuntary attention restores directed attention	Nature triggers evolutionary stress recovery
Both agree on	Natural environments are beneficial · Urban environments create fatigue and stress	

Theory 3: Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB)

Author: Icek Ajzen · Year: 1991

TPB explains why people do — or don't — engage in specific behaviours. Three components shape INTENTION to act:

ATTITUDE 'Do I think this behaviour is good or worthwhile?'

▼

SUBJECTIVE NORMS 'Do the people I care about expect me to do this?'

▼

PERCEIVED BEHAVIOURAL CONTROL 'Do I feel capable and able to actually do this?'

▼

INTENTION The stronger all three, the stronger the intention to act

▼

BEHAVIOUR

🇺🇬 Uganda Connection

Kaveera ban example: To increase compliance you need all three — positive attitudes about the ban, community norms that make using reusable bags normal, AND accessible affordable alternatives so people feel capable. Campaigns that address only attitude while ignoring the other two consistently fail.

Theory 4: Norm Activation Model (NAM)

Author: Shalom Schwartz · Year: 1977

NAM explains altruistic environmental behaviour — action taken from moral obligation, not personal gain. Two conditions must BOTH be present:

AWARENESS OF CONSEQUENCES 'I understand that my behaviour (or inaction) harms the environment or others'

▼

ASCRIPTION OF RESPONSIBILITY 'I feel personally responsible — not the government, not someone else — ME'

▼

PERSONAL MORAL NORM ACTIVATED 'I feel morally obligated to act'

▼

PRO-ENVIRONMENTAL BEHAVIOUR

Key NAM Insight

Awareness alone is NOT enough. A person can know that wetlands are being destroyed and feel sad about it — but if they feel no personal responsibility, no action follows. This is why awareness-only campaigns consistently fail.

Theory 5: Value-Belief-Norm Theory (VBN)

Authors: Paul Stern et al. · Year: 1999

VBN is the most comprehensive theory. It traces the full chain from deep values to behaviour:

VALUES — What matters to you at the deepest level? (Egoistic · Altruistic · Biospheric)

▼

NEW ECOLOGICAL PARADIGM BELIEFS 'Do I believe humans are part of nature and there are ecological limits?'

▼

AWARENESS OF CONSEQUENCES 'Do I see the environmental crisis as real and harmful?'

▼

ASCRIPTION OF RESPONSIBILITY 'Do I feel personally responsible?'

▼

PERSONAL NORM 'I feel morally obligated to act'

▼

PRO-ENVIRONMENTAL BEHAVIOUR

Why VBN matters: if the chain breaks at VALUES (e.g. economic self-interest dominates), no amount of information higher up the chain produces durable behaviour change. The most lasting conservation behaviour comes from people with internalised pro-environmental values.

Theory 6: Place Identity Theory

Authors: Proshansky, Fabian & Kaminoff · Year: 1983

The places we spend significant time become part of who we are. Your childhood home, your village, your campus — these are not just locations. They are part of your psychological identity.

RECOGNITION	SECURITY	MEANING
• Feeling at home in familiar places	• Psychological stability through familiar environments	• Symbolic significance beyond physical features

Implication: people protect what they feel part of. Conservation programs that build people's sense of connection to a place produce more durable conservation behaviour than information campaigns.

Solastalgia

Glenn Albrecht coined this term for the psychological distress caused by watching a place you love change or disappear around you. Not nostalgia (missing a place you left) — but pain from watching your home environment degrade. Communities near disappearing wetlands and forests in Uganda experience this.

Uganda Connection

Buganda sacred forests (ebirungo) were protected for centuries not through law but through cultural identity — they were part of who Buganda people are. This is Place Identity Theory in practice. When conservation programs connect to this existing identity, they are far more effective.

Theory 7: Lewin's Field Theory

Author: Kurt Lewin · Year: 1930s–1940s

$$B = f(P, E)$$

Behaviour (B) is a function of the Person (P) and the Environment (E)

You cannot understand why someone behaves the way they do by looking only at the person. You must also look at the environment. And you cannot understand an environment's effects without considering the person in it.

To change behaviour, you can change...	Example in Uganda
THE PERSON (P) Education, values, knowledge, skills	Environmental education in schools; awareness campaigns
THE ENVIRONMENT (E) Design, infrastructure, regulation, incentives	Building waste bins in markets; subsidising clean cookstoves
BOTH (most effective)	Combining education with infrastructure improvement

🇺🇬 Uganda Connection

A farmer using slash-and-burn agriculture despite knowing its environmental costs is not simply irresponsible. Their behaviour is a product of: their knowledge and values (Person) interacting with: poverty, lack of alternative livelihoods, market conditions, and community norms (Environment). Changing only the person through education — without changing economic conditions — produces limited results.

All 7 Theories at a Glance

Theory	Author	Category	Core Idea in One Line
Attention Restoration Theory	Kaplan & Kaplan	Cognitive	Nature restores depleted mental energy through effortless fascination
Stress Reduction Theory	Ulrich	Physiological	Nature triggers biological stress recovery — lower BP, HR, cortisol
Theory of Planned Behaviour	Ajzen	Behavioural	Attitude + Norms + Perceived Control → Intention → Behaviour
Norm Activation Model	Schwartz	Moral	Awareness + Responsibility → Moral Norm → Behaviour
Value-Belief-Norm Theory	Stern et al.	Values-based	Values → Beliefs → Awareness → Responsibility → Norm → Behaviour
Place Identity Theory	Proshansky	Identity	Places become part of self — people protect what they feel part of
Lewin's Field Theory	Lewin	Ecological	B = f(P,E) — behaviour is always a product of person AND environment

✓Lesson Summary

1. ART and SRT explain what nature does TO people — cognitively and physiologically
2. TPB, NAM, and VBN explain what drives people TO act pro-environmentally
3. Place Identity explains WHY people care about specific environments
4. Lewin's Field Theory is the foundation — B = f(P,E) — underlying everything else
5. No single theory is complete; together they provide a comprehensive toolkit

▯ Quick Revision

1. What is the difference between directed attention and involuntary attention in ART?
2. What did Ulrich's hospital study demonstrate about nature and stress?
3. Name the three components of the Theory of Planned Behaviour.
4. Why does awareness alone not produce behaviour change according to NAM?
5. Write out Lewin's Field Theory formula and explain what each letter means.
6. What is solastalgia and how does it relate to Place Identity Theory?

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Environmental & Conservation Psychology

Module 2 — Perceiving & Valuing the Environment · Lesson 2.1

Environmental Perception & Cognition

▯ Learning Objectives

- Define environmental perception and cognition and explain the difference
- Identify the five filters that cause people to perceive the same environment differently
- Explain spatial cognition and mental maps (Kevin Lynch)
- Distinguish between density and crowding
- Describe the psychological effects of noise

▯ Key Terms

• Environmental perception	• Environmental cognition
• Perceptual filters	• Spatial cognition
• Mental map	• Cognitive map
• Kevin Lynch	• Density
• Crowding	• Noise perception
• Cognitive performance	

1. Perception vs Cognition — What's the Difference?

Environmental PERCEPTION	Environmental COGNITION
How you interpret surroundings using your senses	How you think about, understand, and navigate environments
What you see, hear, smell, feel in a place	How you form mental images and make decisions about places
THE INPUT — what arrives through your senses	THE PROCESSING — what your brain does with that input
Example: noticing the noise of Kampala traffic	Example: knowing which route avoids the worst traffic

2. Why People Perceive the Same Environment Differently

Put 20 people in the same market in Kampala. Some feel energised. Some feel anxious. Some notice the smells; others notice the noise. Why? Five filters shape perception:

PAST EXPERIENCE — A person who grew up near a forest feels safe in woodland; another who only heard fearful stories about forests feels anxious

▼

CULTURE — A wetland is a sacred resource to one community and buildable land to another

▼

EDUCATION & KNOWLEDGE — A trained forester sees signs of erosion that an untrained observer misses

▼

EMOTION & MENTAL STATE — An anxious person perceives threats that a calm person finds relaxing

▼

EXPECTATIONS — Expecting a market to be dirty means you notice dirt more readily

Why This Matters for Conservation

Two communities can receive identical environmental education about wetland protection and respond completely differently — because they bring completely different perceptual filters. Effective conservation communication must understand and work with those filters.

3. Spatial Cognition

Spatial cognition is the mental capacity to understand, represent, and navigate space. It allows you to know where you are, how to get somewhere, and how different places relate to each other.

A boda-boda rider who has navigated Kampala's roads for ten years has highly developed spatial cognition of the city. A student visiting Kampala for the first time is immediately disoriented in the same streets.

4. Mental Maps — Kevin Lynch (1960)

Kevin Lynch asked city residents to draw maps of their own cities. What he found:

- Mental maps are PERSONAL — built from individual lived experience
- Mental maps are SELECTIVE — some landmarks are prominent; others are invisible
- Mental maps are DISTORTED — routes feel shorter or straighter than they are
- Mental maps are DIFFERENT — a taxi driver's map of Kampala looks nothing like a student's

Uganda Connection

Two Makerere students have radically different mental maps of the same campus — because one walks from the hostels to the law faculty daily, while the other cycles from Wandegeya and works in the administration offices. Same campus; two very different mental geographies built from lived experience.

5. Crowding vs Density

DENSITY	CROWDING
Objective — the actual number of people per unit of space	Subjective — the psychological feeling of insufficient space
Measured by counting	Experienced through feelings
The same for everyone in the space	Different for each person depending on past experience, emotion, expectations
Example: 50 people per 100 square metres	Example: one person feels fine; another feels suffocated

Documented effects of crowding:

- Activates stress responses — elevated heart rate, increased anxiety
- Reduces prosocial behaviour — crowded people become less helpful and patient

- Depends on context — the same density in a concert feels exciting; in a prison cell it is torturous

6. Noise Perception

Noise (unwanted or uncontrolled sound) is a major but underappreciated source of environmental stress, especially in Ugandan cities.

Effect	What It Means
Impairs cognitive performance	Concentration, memory, and reading comprehension all decline in noisy environments
Disrupts sleep	Generator noise and traffic noise cause cumulative fatigue over time
Physiological stress continues below awareness	People adapt consciously to noise but blood pressure and cortisol remain elevated

🇺🇬 Uganda Connection

A student studying near a busy road in Jinja cannot retain what they read — not because they lack ability, but because ambient noise is degrading their cognitive performance. They may blame themselves. Environmental psychology provides a better explanation — and a case for school location policies.

✅Lesson Summary

1. Perception is interpreting input through senses; cognition is processing and navigating environments
2. Five filters cause people to perceive the same environment differently: experience, culture, knowledge, emotion, expectations
3. Mental maps are personal, selective, distorted internal images of places — Kevin Lynch (1960)
4. Density is objective (people per space); crowding is subjective (feeling of insufficient space)
5. Noise impairs cognitive performance and creates physiological stress even below conscious awareness

Quick Revision

1. What is the difference between environmental perception and environmental cognition?
2. Name four of the five filters that cause people to perceive environments differently.
3. Who introduced the concept of mental maps, and how were they studied?
4. Why are density and crowding different things? Give an example.
5. Name two documented effects of noise on human performance or wellbeing.

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Environmental & Conservation Psychology

Module 2 — Perceiving & Valuing the Environment · Lesson 2.2

Environmental Attitudes, Values & Culture

🎯 Learning Objectives

- Define attitudes, values, and culture and explain the differences
- Explain the three levels at which attitudes operate
- Identify the three value orientations and their link to environmental behaviour
- Explain how culture, religion, education, and poverty shape environmental attitudes
- Define and apply the three environmental ethics frameworks

🔑 Key Terms

• Environmental attitudes	• Attitude-behaviour gap
• Egoistic values	• Altruistic values
• Biospheric values	• Cultural orientation
• Stewardship ethic	• Anthropocentrism
• Biocentrism	• Ecocentrism
• Aldo Leopold	• Land ethic
• Poverty-environment nexus	

1. Attitudes, Values & Culture — What's the Difference?

These three concepts are related but operate at very different depths. Think of them as layers:

CULTURE — The broadest layer. Shared beliefs, values, customs, and norms of a group
Changes slowest. Shapes everything below it.

VALUES — Fundamental beliefs about what is important and right
Stable across a lifetime. Formed in childhood within cultural context.

ATTITUDES — Relatively stable evaluations of specific things
More responsive to experience and information. Sit on top of values.

2. Attitudes — Three Levels

Level	What It Means	Example
COGNITIVE (what you think)	Beliefs about the environment	'Deforestation is a serious problem in Uganda'
AFFECTIVE (how you feel)	Emotional responses to environmental issues	'I feel sad and angry when I see forests cut down'
BEHAVIOURAL (how you act)	Tendency to behave in certain ways	'I try to use a reusable bag at the market'

The Attitude-Behaviour Gap

People may have positive environmental attitudes but still not act — because of barriers (cost, habit, lack of infrastructure) or competing priorities. Attitude change is necessary but not sufficient for behaviour change.

3. Values — Three Orientations

EGOISTIC Values	ALTRUISTIC Values	BIOSPHERIC Values
• What benefits ME personally? • Low link to environmental behaviour • Economic self-interest dominates	• What benefits OTHER PEOPLE? • Moderate link to environmental behaviour • Social concern motivates action	• What benefits ALL LIVING THINGS? • Strongest link to environmental behaviour • Protects even when personal cost is high

People with strong biospheric values engage in pro-environmental behaviour consistently across many contexts — even when it is costly or inconvenient.

4. Factors That Shape Environmental Attitudes

Factor	How It Shapes Attitudes	Uganda Example
Culture	Cultural frameworks determine how people see the human-nature relationship	Buganda sacred forests (omuvule trees) embedded pro-environmental attitudes through identity
Religion	Stewardship ethic (caring for God's creation) supports environmental protection	Religious leaders mobilised communities around tree planting and wetland protection
Education	More education → greater awareness and more complex understanding	NEMA's school environmental education programs build environmental concern in youth
Personal experience	Direct experience of environmental harm is among the strongest attitude-shapers	Communities in Bududa who experienced landslides have strong attitudes about deforestation
Media	Consistent coverage raises public concern; misinformation creates confusion	Community radio in local languages has been more effective than poster campaigns
Poverty	Survival pressure limits ability to prioritise long-term environmental concerns	Families burning charcoal know it causes deforestation but have no affordable alternative

5. Environmental Ethics — Three Frameworks

Environmental ethics examines our moral obligations toward the natural world. Which framework governs your thinking shapes every decision you make about nature.

ANTHROPOCENTRISM (Human-centred)	BIOCENTRISM (Life-centred)	ECOCENTRISM (Ecosystem-centred)

• Nature has value only if useful to humans • Most common in government policy • Example: protect Lake Victoria because fishing communities need it • Strength: builds on widely accepted human interests	• All living things have intrinsic value • Underpins animal rights movements • Example: protect mountain gorillas because they have a right to exist, not just for tourists • Resonant with many traditional African cosmologies	• The whole ecosystem matters most • Aldo Leopold's Land Ethic • Example: remove Water Hyacinth from Lake Victoria to protect the ecosystem, even if individual plants suffer • Justifies removing invasive species

Aldo Leopold's Land Ethic

'A thing is right when it tends to preserve the integrity, stability, and beauty of the biotic community. It is wrong when it tends otherwise.' — The foundational statement of ecocentric ethics.

✓Lesson Summary

1. Culture (broadest) → Values → Attitudes (most specific). Each layer shapes the one above it
2. Attitudes operate at three levels: cognitive, affective, and behavioural
3. Biospheric values produce the most consistent and durable pro-environmental behaviour
4. Six factors shape environmental attitudes: culture, religion, education, personal experience, media, poverty
5. Three ethical frameworks: anthropocentrism (human-centred), biocentrism (life-centred), ecocentrism (ecosystem-centred)

? Quick Revision

1. What is the difference between attitudes and values? Which is deeper?
2. Name the three levels at which environmental attitudes operate.
3. Which value orientation is most strongly linked to consistent pro-environmental behaviour?
4. How does poverty affect environmental attitudes and behaviour?
5. Define anthropocentrism and biocentrism and give one example of each.

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Environmental & Conservation Psychology

Module 3 — Pro-Environmental Behaviour · Lesson 3.1

Pro-Environmental Behaviour — Drivers, Barriers & Theory in Action

▯ Learning Objectives

- Define pro-environmental behaviour and give Uganda-relevant examples
- Identify and explain the six key drivers of pro-environmental behaviour
- Explain the four categories of barriers that prevent action
- Apply TPB, NAM, and VBN to a real Ugandan environmental case

▯ Key Terms

• Pro-environmental behaviour	• Attitude-behaviour gap
• Descriptive norms	• Injunctive norms
• Perceived behavioural control	• Moral responsibility
• Structural barriers	• Psychological barriers
• Social barriers	• Economic barriers
• Value-action gap	• Collective action problem
• Free-rider problem	• Kaveera ban

1. What Is Pro-Environmental Behaviour?

Pro-environmental behaviour (PEB) is any action — individual or collective — that protects the natural environment or reduces harm to it.

Individual Actions	Collective Actions
Using a reusable bag at the market	Organising a community clean-up of a wetland
Switching off lights and unplugging chargers	Advocating to local council for better waste management
Using a charcoal-saving cookstove	Participating in tree-planting events organised by LCs or NGOs
Reporting illegal logging to NEMA	Forming a community group to monitor wetland encroachment

2. Six Drivers of Pro-Environmental Behaviour

#	Driver — What It Is and Why It Matters
1	ATTITUDES — Positive attitude toward the environment increases likelihood of action. But attitude alone is insufficient (attitude-behaviour gap).
2	SOCIAL NORMS — What the people around you do and expect is often more powerful than personal attitudes. Descriptive norms (what most people do) and injunctive norms (what is expected) both drive behaviour.

3	MORAL RESPONSIBILITY — People act when they feel personally responsible. Awareness without responsibility produces knowledge but not action (NAM).
4	VALUES — Biospheric values produce the most consistent PEB. Campaigns connecting to existing cultural and religious values produce more durable change.
5	PERCEIVED BEHAVIOURAL CONTROL — People act when they feel capable and have access to the tools and infrastructure needed. If recycling bins do not exist, motivation alone cannot produce recycling.
6	INCENTIVES & DISINCENTIVES — External rewards and penalties can produce short-term behaviour change. But behaviour driven only by external incentives stops when incentives are removed. Internal motivation is more durable.

3. Four Categories of Barriers

STRUCTURAL Barriers	PSYCHOLOGICAL Barriers	SOCIAL Barriers
• Lack of recycling infrastructure • No affordable sustainable alternatives • Weak enforcement of environmental law • → Cannot act without these	• Value-action gap (good values, no action) • Optimism bias ('won't affect me') • Psychological distance ('too far away') • Helplessness ('what can one person do?')	• Peer pressure to conform to harmful norms • Collective action / free-rider problem • Lack of visible community leadership

ECONOMIC Barriers (fourth category)	Example in Uganda
Poverty forces short-term decision-making	Farmer cuts tree for immediate cash knowing it causes long-term harm
Sustainable alternatives cost more	LPG cookstoves are unaffordable; families use charcoal instead
Survival overrides long-term thinking	Family food security takes priority over wetland protection

Key Lesson

Effective environmental programs address BARRIERS — not just motivations. They ask: What structural barriers can we remove? What psychological barriers can we address? What social barriers can we shift? What economic barriers can we lower? Programs that only run information campaigns and ignore these barriers consistently fail.

4. TPB, NAM & VBN Applied: Uganda's Kaveera Ban

Uganda banned single-use plastic bags (kaveera) in 2009. Despite the ban, compliance has been incomplete. Here is what the three theories tell us:

Theory	What It Diagnoses	What It Recommends
TPB	Attitude: mixed (some see ban as inconvenient). Norms: weak (vendors still provide bags, so non-compliance is normalised). Perceived control: low (affordable alternatives not always available)	Strengthen attitudes + shift social norms through enforcement + improve access to affordable alternatives

NAM	Awareness: improving but not complete. Responsibility: many people feel it is 'a government problem' or 'a factory problem', not theirs personally	Connect individual choices (accepting a plastic bag at market) explicitly to community consequences (flooding of Bwaise)
VBN	Chain breaks at VALUES for many people — economic convenience dominates biospheric concern	Engage cultural and religious leaders to connect environmental stewardship to existing deep values

The Synthesis
All three theories say the same thing from different angles: information campaigns alone are insufficient. Effective behaviour change requires working at the practical level (access and infrastructure), the social level (norms and leadership), the moral level (personal responsibility), and the values level (cultural and religious engagement).

✅Lesson Summary

1. Pro-environmental behaviour includes any action that protects or reduces harm to the environment
2. Six drivers: attitudes, social norms, moral responsibility, values, perceived control, incentives
3. Four barrier categories: structural, psychological, social, economic
4. TPB diagnoses attitude-norm-control barriers; NAM identifies the responsibility gap; VBN identifies the values root
5. Comprehensive programs address barriers AND motivations at all four levels simultaneously

Quick Revision

1. Define pro-environmental behaviour and give two Uganda examples.
2. Name the six drivers of pro-environmental behaviour.
3. What is the value-action gap and why does it happen?
4. Give one example each of a structural, psychological, social, and economic barrier.
5. Using the kaveera ban, show how TPB, NAM, and VBN each diagnose a different problem.